

HEALTH AT A PREMIUM

OPD plans offer different levels of coverage ranging from tele/physical consultation, diagnostics and pharmacy bills

Features	ManipalCigna Prime Advantage	ABHI's Activ Health Platinum Enhanced			Niva Bupa Smart Health +		TATA Medicare Premier
		Option 1	Option 2	Option 3	Acute Best Consult	Acute Best Care	
Waiting Period	30 days	Day 1	Day 1	Day 1	Day 1	Day 1	2 years
OPD amount	Up to ₹20,000 per annum in-built. Can go up to ₹50,000	Unlimited general physical consultations	Unlimited general consultations (Tele/physical)	Option 2, along with two physical specialist consultations	24x7 unlimited teleconsultations with specialists from Apollo Hospitals	Unlimited teleconsultations; pharmacy and diagnostics bills up to ₹20,000	Up to ₹5,000 in-built; Covers up to ₹10,000 related to root canal, tooth extractions, etc.
Teleconsultation	Yes	-	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	-
Physical consultation	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	-	-	Yes
Diagnostics	Yes	-	-	-	-	Yes	-
Prescribed medicine	Yes	-	-	-	-	Yes	Yes
Premium*	₹9,783 + (₹363/743 for OPD cover of ₹30,000/50,000)	₹8,330 + ₹703	₹8,330 + ₹942	₹8,330 + ₹1,178	₹9,277 + ₹1,262	₹9,277 (+₹3,932/5,435/6,185/6,825 for cover of ₹5K/10K/15K/20K)	₹13,663 for ₹10 lakh sum insured

*annual premium for a Delhi-based 35-year-old man; **Source** PolicyBazaar

just ₹297, with the sum insured of ₹6,000. Similarly, for a 60-year-old person who wants the most comprehensive OPD coverage, the premium will work out to ₹6,558 for a sum insured of ₹55,000.

THE FINE PRINT

OPD policies can offer wide protection—from doctor consultations, lab tests, pharmacy bills and preventive health check-ups to mental wellness and diet and nutrition counselling. But it is vital to note the exclusions, too. For instance, some cases that are not included in the plans are cosmetic treatments, hazardous and adventure sports, non-prescribed dietary supplements, treatment for addictions, spas, self-injury and STDs (sexually transmitted diseases), etc.

But a major concern with the OPD plans is the cumbersome claims process done through reimbursements. Sample this: the policy holder needs to fill out a form and submit bills and other required documents to claim the insured

amount. Some of the new plans, however, do offer cashless services where one books an appointment with a doctor online, post which the claim is settled through the app.

“At ManipalCigna, all OPD claims are paid on a cashless basis. This is mainly done for two reasons: First is to reduce fraudulent claims that may arise from consultations; and second is to ensure that a customer never has to feel the pinch of paying any expense from their pockets,” says Prasun Sikdar, MD & CEO of ManipalCigna. “We have also built a strong network of hospitals so that our customers get quality healthcare.” All its claims processes for cashless OPD are app-based. A customer simply needs to book an appointment at a network hospital at a time suitable for them and visit it at that time.

Dasgupta adds that ICICI Lombard's services, too, are cashless and delivered in a paperless manner through its in-house ‘IL TakeCare’ app. “Customers can place a request for any of the services like booking

an appointment with the doctors or ordering pharmacy delivery at home or visiting labs for diagnostics, through the app,” he says.

Another key factor to examine before buying an OPD plan is that there should be enough empanelled doctors for a quick consultation. Next, you should also look at the coverage allotted for overall and per consultation OPD treatment, as it should be enough to cover consultation costs, medicines and lab tests. Moreover, it is always good to have a policy that provides the facility of OPD throughout the day.

A basic health insurance policy covers only hospitalisation costs, whereas OPD plans provide an additional layer of coverage that is especially useful in cases where a person has any pre-existing condition or lower immunity. But before buying an OPD plan, you should check the coverage, its exclusions as well as the network of doctors available in your area. **BT**

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